

By Hollywood standards, the budget for Ang Lee's movie was small: \$17 million. Studio executives were taken aback when it grossed \$128 million in the US alone, and nearly \$215 million internationally.

Lien live by. She is contemptuous of their self-discipline, or as she sees it, their self-repression. "Stop talking like a monk," she retorts, when Li Mu Bai tries to advise her that the sword is a state of mind. She has taken a lover, Lo (Chang Chen), a bandit, with whom she is sexually intimate, and defies her family (unthinkable in China at that time) by escaping on her wedding night from an arranged, respectable marriage to a nobleman.

Jen Yu acknowledges that Li Mu Bai's martial skills are greater than those of Jade Fox, and she wants him as her teacher. When he agrees, she says that he



is only doing so because he desires her sexually.

Jade Fox was once a student of Li Mu Bai's old master, but killed him when he tried to take sexual advantage of her. Her hostility as a character, and her fury and vengefulness, could also be sexual in origin. The entire story is driven by sexual undercurrents.

Fantastical fighting

In another departure from genre tradition, the fighting scenes are not so much staged as choreographed, becoming extraordinary aerial ballets. In the most stunning sequence, with Li Mu Bai fighting Jen Yu amid swaying bamboos, the effect was not achieved with computer trickery but with the actors flying on wires. The result is enigmatic rather than violent, capturing the mystery and poetry of a mythical ancient China. ■



Ang Lee Director

Born in 1954 in Taiwan, Ang Lee graduated from the National Taiwan College of Arts before moving to the US. His first critical success came with *The Wedding Banquet*, the first of several movies made with screenwriter James Schamus. Lee returned to Taiwan to make *Eat Drink Man Woman* (1994), a critical and commercial success. His adaptation of Jane Austen's *Sense and Sensibility* (1995), with a screenplay by the movie's star, Emma Thompson, revealed his range. The tragedy *The Ice Storm* and the US Civil War drama *Ride with the Devil* (1999) were followed by *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* and *The Hulk* (2003). He won an Oscar for Best Director with *Brokeback Mountain* (2005), about the gay relationship between two cowboys. A second Oscar came in 2012 with *Life of Pi*.

Key movies

1993 *The Wedding Banquet*
1997 *The Ice Storm*
2000 *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon*
2012 *Life of Pi*

Major fight scenes

